

"The most comprehensive approach for an absolute transformation"

THE PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR BECOMING AN OFFICER

NFA'S OFFICIAL HANDBOOK FOR SSB PREPARATION



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SSB Psych Tests: Overview

SSB conducts a comprehensive test of personality. Assessment of human psychology is the essence of all the three testing techniques, namely: "Psychology", "GTO" and "Interview". Hence to treat "Psychology Test" as the sole test of psychology would be wrong.

Our psychology, attitude, beliefs, motivation, willpower and confidence build over our lives and depend upon our genetics, parental guidance, culture, environment and, most importantly, the choices we make.

Thus, one prepares for SSB by the way one lives their life. There is **no specific formula for SSB preparation** other than leading a balanced life. Under-developed aspects of our personality can be improved by changing our life-styles.

Before discussing the Psychology Tests, I have included short articles on certain important facets of our personality and also suggested methods to improve them.

Chapter 1: Essays Related to Personality Development

Essay 1: Who am I?

Who am I? This is a very difficult question to answer for most of humanity. We do not know ourselves well enough- our **self concept** is hazy. Our self concept is often a summation of consistent views expressed by others about us. The views are often something like this:

Mother:

"You can never get up on time!"

"You are totally irresponsible!"

"You can never keep your things properly!"

"You stay in bad company- your friends will spoil you!"

"You are only fond of playing; see your neighbour, how much he studies! I don't know if you will be able to do any work!"

"You are too simple! The World is too bad! I don't know how you will manage?"

Teacher:

"You talk too much!"

"You never finish your homework in time!"

"You don't pay attention in class!"

"The way you are going, you will find it difficult to get admission in any good college!"

Friend:

"You are very straightforward; you should be more diplomatic!"

"X has said that he will beat you in the race! He is practicing very hard!"

Should we form a self concept on the basis of above views, which are all well meaning, but reflect the insecurities of the Mother, Teacher and Friend? Is there another way to form a self concept?

Introspection:

This is another method. You assess yourself based on self analysis and ignore the views of others. This method has only limited reliability. We may over-rate/ underrate our positive/ negative traits. Our assessment is subjective and ignores the value of demonstrated behaviour.

Let us learn about a very important research- **"Self fulfilling Prophecy"**.

Self Fulfilling Prophecy (Pygmalion Research - 1968)

The original research of Rosenthal and Jacobson focused on an experiment at an elementary school where students took intelligence pre-tests. Rosenthal and Jacobson then informed the teachers of the names of twenty percent of the students in the school who were showing "unusual potential for intellectual growth" and would bloom academically within the year.

Unknown to the teachers, these students were selected randomly with no relation to the initial test. When Rosenthal and Jacobson tested the students eight months later, they discovered that the randomly selected students who teachers thought would bloom scored significantly higher.

Higher expectations of teachers induced higher performance. This showed the immense power of the '**self fulfilling prophecy**'. This logic of 'self fulfilling prophecy' applies almost universally. High expectations induce high performance, while low expectations induce low performance.

Can I Know/ Should I Know Myself?

Let us note some facts.

Fact #1 - It is very difficult to form an accurate clear **self concept**.

Fact #2 - Human capacity for growth is unlimited.

Fact #3 - By being proactive we can unlearn poor habits and learn good habits and, thus change our personalities for the better.

Keeping the above knowledge in mind, can we now formulate the answer to the question-"Who am I?"

Forming a Clear Self Concept

We are able to develop a hazy self concept through opinion of others and by introspection. We can live with it, or make it more accurate by assessing ourselves:

'FORM A SELF CONCEPT ON THE BASIS OF CONSISTENT, DEMONSTRATED BEHAVIOUR, RATHER THAN ON THE BASIS OF OUR THOUGHTS and PERCEPTIONS'.

It is not an easy exercise, but feasible to form a more accurate self concept.

Create your Personality

Now visualise as to what type of person you would like to be – your ideal self image. There would be differences in the ideal self image and the self concept. Some habits will have to be given up, which are unworthy of you, but form part of your personality because of various environmental influences. It will take time and effort. Similarly some new habits will have to be formed. Thus you will always remain on a journey of self improvement, because as you mature your ideas will also evolve and so your ideal self image will also keep changing.

All this improvement will take place in incremental small steps.

A reactive person will accept himself/herself as evolved due to the impact of genes and environment. The person believes that the negative aspects of the personality are to be lived with. For a reactive person the answer to the question 'who am I?' is that basic nature cannot be changed and I am how God made me and the environment shaped me.

Proactive Person's Answer to Question- Who am I?

The answer to the question, 'who am I?' for a proactive person will be –

" I AM AN EVOLVING PERSON, WHO HAS A FAIRLY ACCURATE IDEA OF WHO I WOULD LIKE TO BE AND AM SLOWLY MOVING IN THAT DIRECTION"

Essay 2 :

Understanding Attribution Theory-

Developing The Right Attitude

Bear in mind that our attitude determines our success in life.

Attribution Theory

Read these statements:

"I failed in Math test because last night we had no current and I could not study"

"I was bowled because the ball did not rise, because of the bad pitch"

"I performed poorly in college because I got into bad company"

"I did not study well because my family environment was not conducive"

These are some commonly heard statements. These statements demonstrate rationalisation of behaviour by an individual to others and even to himself/herself. Rationalisation to self, creates a flawed self concept and also has the negative impact of not learning from own mistakes. Such an individual is likely to repeat the same mistake again and again. His stubbornness will prevent improvement. Now read these statements:

"I got a good rank because I worked hard"

"I scored a century because I concentrated well"

It is common human nature to attribute good things/successes to ourselves – that is our capabilities and effort, and for our failures we tend to blame external factors. This in brief is the essence of "Attribution Theory" – a topic in the field of Psychology. The first series of statements are blaming external factors for a poor performance and second set of statements are taking credit for good performance.

We are Responsible for our Lives

The truth is that in the long run external factors do not play a major role in how our lives and careers progress, but primarily depend upon our abilities and efforts. We should remember this important truth and attribute failures to ourselves, as well as successes. In short we should realise that we are responsible for our lives- good and bad both.

Developing Right Attitude

The right attitude of a proactive person who takes responsibility for his actions and works to improve his future would be:

"I failed in SSB because my GK and English are weak; I will improve them and succeed next time!"

"My parents don't trust me because of my past actions; I will make myself trustworthy and their attitude will automatically change!"

Thus, understanding the Attribution Theory, remembering and utilising it to **develop the right attitude** will set us on the path to continuous progress and success in life.

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Essay 3:

Importance of Motivation

Some very commonly encountered problems:

1. "I started a weight loss program. It was okay for the first week, but now I find it difficult to continue."
2. "I find Math classes very boring and wait for them to get over"
3. "I am preparing for the IAS exam, but I find it difficult and uninteresting to study ancient Indian and World History"
4. "When I go to office/class on Monday, I am already looking forward to the weekend!"
5. "I just don't find the energy to go through the same old routine of life"

All these problems, apparently different, have a common thread binding them- "weak motivation".

Let us examine the concept of "motivation"

Understanding Importance of Motivation in Life

For a hungry and thirsty man food and water are very strong motives to work. It is the lowest order of need (physiological). This is often not the case

for most of us in the middle class. As per Maslow's theory, there are other motivational needs as we progress up in the need hierarchy – namely "safety", "social", "esteem" and "self actualisation" What experience shows is that **selfish motives** are weaker than

altruistic motives. Any mother will tell you that her motivation to teach her children is much stronger than pursuing her own higher studies. Similarly a committed teacher will find motivation to teach his students stronger than pursuing his higher studies. In my own case, I could keep awake and work for long hours at night when I knew that the lives of my troops and civilian population were endangered. I could not have done so for selfish reasons.

Intrinsic and Extrinsic Motivation

When I do a job, solve Math problems, read History, play a game, which I like, irrespective of any external reward I am 'intrinsically motivated'. When I do the same activities but the 'motivation' is the reward, like salary, marks in exams, earning from game, the motivation is extrinsic. **Intrinsic motivation is much stronger than motivation that is extrinsic.** An example of intrinsic motivation is the reason the protagonist in '3 Idiots' gives for studying mechanical engineering – his love for machines. A combination of **intrinsic** and **altruistic motives** is a very strong force. For example, take Tendulkar or Leander Paes playing for India. They both find the game **INTRINSICALLY MOTIVATING and combined with the MOTIVATION TO PERFORM FOR THE COUNTRY (ALTRUISTIC MOTIVE), THE FORCE IS VERY STRONG.**

Motivating ourselves to accomplish Goals

We have understood the concept of motivation. Now, we will learn about motivating ourselves to accomplish goals. This will help us to energise our daily lives.

Staying Fit

We all want to be fit, but rarely are we able to define what it means in specific terms. Usually it would be advice from a doctor, or self image, often without a clear target. Let us see how we can make our motivation stronger in this case. It is important to have a well defined, measurable clear goal.

1. I could lay down a goal like running 10 km in 40/50/60 minutes in 3 months. If I achieve this then my weight loss goal would get automatically achieved, without having taken recourse to any popular (mostly unhealthy diet plans). I would be healthier and stronger.
2. I could have a goal of **"NOT FALLING ILL"**, because I have to look after my family and set an example for them. To attain this goal I have to exercise regularly and control my food intake: **(ALTRUISTIC MOTIVE)**.
3. I could develop a love for exercising (INTRINSIC MOTIVATION) and combine it with a need to not fall ill and set an example **(ALTRUISTIC MOTIVE)**. This will be a very strong motivating force.

Math

Often students link studies only with passing exams, with no relationship with future life, which is a very weak motive. They should realise the value of knowing the subject in future life.

1. Realise that in the career which I intend to pursue to look after my family, knowing Math is essential: **(ALTRUISTIC MOTIVE)**.
2. I study Math because I like Math, passing exams is incidental: **(INTRINSIC MOTIVATION)**.
3. I can tell myself that I like challenges. If I find Math difficult, then it is a challenge to be overcome.
4. I should strive to get a combination of the above two motivational forces to succeed in knowing the subject.

Conclusion

So whenever you face problems of motivation like the ones discussed, or unique to your case, you should examine your motives deeply and get them aligned correctly. I assure you will feel energised to accomplish your goals.

Essay 4:

How to Increase Self Confidence?

A lot of my students face problems of low self confidence and they want to know as to **how to increase self confidence**. In this post I discuss the subject.

Understanding Self Confidence

Self confidence can be understood as comprising of two facets of our personality. First is our sense of self efficacy. This means that we see ourselves capable of mastering skills and achieving goals in a specific field. We believe that if we learn and work hard in a field we will succeed. This type of confidence leads people to accept difficult challenges, and persist in the face of setbacks. Example: A child who likes Math and can easily solve his class Math problems will accept the challenge of solving Math problems of greater difficulty of a higher class. He may not succeed immediately, but will succeed ultimately because of his **self confidence**.

The second facet of **self confidence** is the idea of self esteem. It implies a more general sense that we can cope with what is going on in our lives. We consider ourselves competent at what we do and have a sense that we can do things if we focus on them. Example: Farhan Akhtar had the belief that he could play the role of Milkha Singh in the famous movie. He believed that he could look and act like Milkha Singh. He did a great job. The most important part was his self opinion (**self confidence**).

Is it Possible to Enhance Self Confidence?

Popular belief is that it is possible to **enhance self-confidence** by external affirmations and positive thinking. There is some truth in this. It is most important to **increase self confidence** by setting and achieving goals – thereby **building competence**. Without this underlying competence, we do not **enhance self-confidence**, but build shallow over-**confidence**, which brings upsets and failures in life.

Bad news for the modern society and in accordance with my Guru, Stephen Covey's philosophy is: "There is no short cut, or quick fix solution!"

The good news is that increasing **self confidence** is genuinely achievable. It requires focus and determination. Another good part is that the things you will do to **enhance self-confidence** will also build success – after all, your **confidence** will come from real, solid achievements.

Vital Mindset to increase Self Confidence

- Carry out an introspection to assess your strengths and weaknesses as on date. Make a note of your strengths. Think about them every day.
- Positive thinking: Our mind often has vivid memories of failures and successes.

Failures could be like:

- You fell down as a child and others laughed.

- You embarrassed yourself by some stupid behaviour.
- You became blank when faced with a crowd.
- You became speechless when your teacher or boss asked something you knew.

Successes could be like:

- You recited a poem in class as a child.
- You solved a problem on black board in class.
- At home you solved a problem for your parents when they were stuck.
- You hit the balloon with the air gun at a fair.

Positive thinking is to think more often about the successes than the failures. If you are facing an opponent you have lost to 9 times out of 10, think only about when you won, before facing him again. This confidence will increase your chances of success!

Enhancing Self Confidence

Wherever you are in life and whatever you are doing do the following:

- Set small achievable goals and accomplish them with determination and focus.
- Gradually increase the level of your goals.

- Celebrate your success and keep remembering the small successes.
- As you **increase self confidence** try to place yourself in situations in which you had failed and visualise yourself succeeding in imagination and then go ahead and do it.
- **Increase self confidence on a strong foundation of consistent hard work and successes!**

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Essay 5:

Improving Willpower and Determination

People with good **willpower and determination** are happier and more successful than those who are weaker in these qualities. It is a vital quality required for most of our difficult endeavours. The quality is far more important than talent. Willpower can be improved. Just the way we can improve our physical muscles, so can we improve our willpower. In this chapter we shall discuss simple practical ways to improve our willpower and determination.

Health is Important

Willpower is a mental quality. It is however dependent upon the health of the body. A hungry and tired man will display weaker willpower compared with a person with matching inherent qualities who has had a good sleep and is well fed. In our efforts to improve our will power we need the support of healthy eating, sleeping and exercise habits.

Train the 'Willpower muscle' with Small Steps

We can apply the analogy of physical muscles to increasing our willpower and determination by gradually loading the muscle to increase strength. Under training will not help and overtraining will injure the muscle (deplete willpower). If you want to run a marathon from the level of being

able to run one km you will find the target overwhelming. This is the problem which causes most people to give up early. They cannot believe that the goal is attainable. It is however, very much possible to add one km, or 500m per week to your current level. In this manner you can reach the capability to run marathon in about one year. Imagine how much physical and mental strength improvement is practicable in one year! If you are impatient with your progress you are likely to end up having abandoned the plan. Step by step is the right approach to attain our long term goals.

Meditation for Willpower

Regular meditation is a great way to improve **willpower**. It is a direct way to control our thoughts and prevent them from wandering in an undesired and unproductive manner. Even 10 min per day will help to improve **willpower**.

Small Steps in Self Control

Plan goals and actions for one hour, or one day and strive to attain them. Push yourself beyond your comfort zone of effort, but do not overdo it. Do not feel frustrated by your rate of progress, but have patience. Reward yourself for little improvement. This will lead to bigger improvements by and by (just like the marathon running logic explained above).

Improve Self Control to Overcome Bad Habits Step by Step

You may be drinking too much tea, gossiping too much, wasting time on social media, overspending, having low attention span, or having any undesirable habit. All these have to be overcome by the small steps method of pa-

tience and perseverance. You will not only become a better person, but also would have improved your willpower.

Resist Temptations by Deliberate Distraction or Simple Self Control

You can distract your mind away from temptations by deliberate effort, or if you are confident then just make effort to delay gratification. This is also a good way of improving willpower.

Conclusion

Willpower and determination are vital for success and happiness in our lives. These qualities can be developed by patience and perseverance by taking small steps towards our desired goals. Efforts in this direction will pay great dividends. Many students of No Frills Academy have become much more effective in their personal lives by adopting some of the measures discussed above.

Essay 6:

How to Improve Reasoning Ability?

Reasoning ability means using reason or logic in thinking out a problem in accordance with the principles of logic or reason. Reasoning ability also implies using rational thinking and not getting affected by emotions. Rational thinking would imply having a scientific temper of inquiry and reliance on empirical evidence rather than blind faith in accepted social and religious norms.

Popular belief is that reasoning ability is largely genetically determined. This is not true. Genetics determine **reasoning ability** to some extent. Reasoning ability, like practically all human endowments, can be improved. In this chapter we will discuss how to improve reasoning ability?

Understanding the Reasoning Process

Unless we know how someone arrived at a conclusion, we can critique only the answer or conclusion. If we break the process of thinking into individual steps, we are better able to critique both our own thinking process and that of others. Math teachers often advise their students to show their work. If all that counts is the answer, the work (or process) is irrelevant. Showing the work allows teachers (and students) to know just where the students may have gone wrong. Did they totally miss a concept or did they make a simple transposition error? This helps in future guidance and improving reasoning ability.

Step by Step Process helps Comprehension

An example of learning a new skill is a Tennis serve, A coach breaks down the process into a series of steps that address elements such as positioning the feet, tossing the ball, and moving the racket. Each of these skills can be examined and practiced independently and then in combination. When each element is correctly applied in concert with the others, the process of serving a tennis ball is complete. The same process holds true for **rational thinking**. As in learning a skill, we can break problem solving into individual steps that we practice. We can thus improve our rational thinking—and help others improve theirs.

Approach to solving Math Problems to Improve Reasoning Ability

Math is the subject best suited to improve logical thinking. Unfortunately the over emphasis on getting the right answer takes us away from the process of reasoning. The reasoning muscles are getting trained when the problem is in the process of being solved. If the child gets the answer straight away then the mind has not received the requisite training. This unfortunately is happening today through impatient parents and tutors. It would be good if just hints are given and the student is encouraged to continue effort to solve the problem. The same analogy applies to other subjects as well.

Consider Reasoning Ability as a Muscle

By training we can improve all our natural endowments. Consider **reasoning ability** as a muscle. It can be improved by systematic training. So, train hard and train often.

Meditation/Visualisation to Improve Reasoning Ability

Meditation involves focusing the mind and removing distractions. It is a good exercise to improve reasoning ability.

Visualising is another great mental exercise. You can create a mental image in your mind about anything of concern; hold that image with clarity to improve logical thought process.

Regular Writing to Improve Reasoning Ability

We often think that we understand a particular thing or concept. We are surprised when we try writing it down and realise that we lacked clarity and had not understood the concept in totality. Writing helps us gain clarity of understanding and **improve reasoning ability**.

Teaching to Improve Reasoning Ability

When we have to teach someone it is a great mental exercise. My experience shows that students who have been teaching regularly gain greater clarity of concepts compared with others. This is another way to improve reasoning ability.

Diverse Interests, Sports and Games Improve Reasoning Ability

Chess and cross word puzzles are popular games for mental exercise. Various other games, both mental and physical provide scope for improving the mental muscles. The more we get out of our comfort zones the better challenge we provide to our mind to grow.

Conclusion

The above discussion would have clarified that reasoning ability can be improved. There are a large number of ways in which this can be achieved. Some important methods have been discussed above. Please understand that training of mental muscles is just like the physical muscles. Parents must allow the children to exert their minds to solve problems and not provide immediate solutions, thus depriving the young minds of vital exercise. Grown up adults, when confronted with complex problems must break them down into simpler and smaller steps and solve them. As we solve more, diverse and challenging problems in life our problem solving skills are consistently improving and thus our reasoning ability.

Chapter 2

Psychology Tests : Facts You Should Know

Personality assessment conducted in SSBs is based on the science of psychology. Psychology is not an absolute science, unlike the physical sciences known to us. It implies that there are not always definite, 'yes/no' answers to problems or situations.

Psychology tests in SSB are conducted based on projective technique. Projective technique works on the established fact that when we describe ambiguous stimuli, we actually describe ourselves, and reveal our personalities, the conscious part (of which we are well aware) and even the unconscious part (of which we are unaware). The unconscious part of the brain is assessed by some as being 9/10th part and conscious only 1/10th part. In projective technique, a person is shown ambiguous stimuli (such as words, situations or pictures) and asked to interpret them in some way. Such stimuli allow relative freedom in projecting one's own interests and feelings into them and reacting in any way that seems appropriate. Projective techniques are believed to be sensitive to unconscious dimensions of personality. Defence mechanisms, latent impulses, and anxieties can be inferred from data gath-

ered from projective techniques by expert psychologists. *Assessment by expert psychologists is an art and not a science.*

Psychology tests arouse the greatest of interest among SSB aspirants. Aspirants waste maximum time on preparing for psychology tests. From the nature of questions asked by aspirants, I realise that there are a large number of misconceptions about the tests. I have tried to clarify the major misconceptions about psychology tests in SSB, in this book.

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Chapter 3

Assessment Method

It requires no psychological genius to assess qualities like communication skills in English. The quality of language written is in front of the assessor! Your vocabulary, spellings, grammar and expression are available for assessment.

Reasoning ability is assessed based on the understanding and logic apparent in understanding photos in TAT and situations in SRTs.

If a candidate leaves a large portion of the test unanswered it clearly shows:

- Low level of 'speed of decision making'.
- Low level of mental stamina.

The psychologist will have reasons to assess his reasoning ability and his time management in life to be of a low order!

Is there any value in understanding the assessment method?

The above information is given just to explain that consistent patterns display the true personality of a candidate. It is not possible for candidates to

discern consistency in their responses to assess qualities. This job can be done only by experts.

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Chapter 4

How to Approach Psychology Tests?

SSB aspirants focus on individual aspects of the test. They focus separately on WAT, SRTs, TAT and self description. They try to plan strategy to excel in them. They are unable to understand any connection between them. From the perspective of the assessor there is little relevance of isolated responses. The assessor constructs a holistic and cohesive profile of the individual based on the consistency of responses. All the 15 OIQs are assessed in this way. Inconsistent and coached responses will have no positive impact on the assessment. Such responses get ignored.

Assessment of an individual is done based on the entire written tests and not piece meal, like separate assessment of WAT, TAT and SRT. Personality of an individual is one whole and the various inputs help to construct it. For example, If a candidate consistently only reports matters to authority and waits for others to do something and avoids personal action to resolve problems in TAT and SRTs then his leadership abilities and courage maybe of a low order.

Now that the approach to Psychology Tests is clear, let us learn about the tests.

Screening Process

The screening process can be assumed to be of approximately of 100 marks.
Then the division of marks will be :

Individual Aspects:

- OIR Test- 25%
- PPDT story- 25%
- Narration of story- 25%

Group Behaviour:

- Discussion: 25%

Picture Perception and Description Test (PPDT)

Requirement in PPDT

PPDT involves three aspects – first, is writing a *story*; second, is narrating the story; and third, is a discussion on the story in a group.

You will be shown a black and white, hazy photo for 30 seconds. You are required to write some particulars in the available box in the answer sheet, which includes number of characters, their age, sex and mood. You have to identify the main character and build the story around him/her. It is convenient to name the character (helps in discussion stage). You are required to describe what the scene in the photo depicts (what is going on?) You have to visualise and write, what led to the present scene (what happened in the past?) You have to foresee the future and write it. (What will happen in the future?) The entire story has to be written in about 3 minutes and submitted.

Avoid

Preconceived Story. Some coached candidates (generally ACC and SCO entries), come with a misconception that the time is too less to make a *story* and hence come with a preconceived *story* and fit it there. Often the main character in such stories is narrated as a young man who joins the Defence Services and also gets a decoration! This type of story is made even when there is nothing in the photo to suggest any part of such a story! There are several such "positive" coaching academy type stories which can be easily found out by the assessors. Such stories have an adverse impact on the clearance of the Stage 1 by the subject candidate.

Stories Displaying Wrong Interpretation of Positive Thinking. Experience shows that quite a few coached candidates are over enthusiastic about "positive thinking" and display it in an unnatural manner in their stories. E.g: In an obviously tragic scene such candidates will state that the mood of the main character is positive. Such stories can be easily found out and have an adverse impact on the clearance of the Stage 1 by the subject candidate.

Common Misconceptions. Some male candidates have a misconception that *the main character must be of their age and gender!* As a result of this wrong notion some candidates write story about a male character while the photo shows a female. This goes against them because the assessors are led to conclude that such candidates are unable to interpret clearly what is shown and lack practical sense.

Do This

Write a natural and realistic story that comes to your mind on seeing the picture. The moods, etc of characters should be stated as observed. Positive thinking means that even if the photo shows something adverse, or tragic, the candidate foresees that in the future things will become all right, with the main character playing a proactive part in the same.

The main character should be proactive and do something for the betterment of the existing situation.

Discussion in PPDT

Candidates are organised in groups of 14-15 for group discussion. Each candidate is required to narrate his *story* by turn. After everyone has narrated his/her *story* the group is required to discuss the same and arrive at a consensus *story*. The group is required to nominate a leader who has to narrate the *story* on behalf of the entire group.

Do This

- Narrate your *story* confidently in a clear voice in about one minute (for repeater batches-40 sec is safe).
- Remain confident about being selected, remain relaxed and do not feel pressurised to force your views on others, in the fear that others will dominate you.
- Don't look at the assessors while narrating the story, or during the discussion.
- Listen to the speakers attentively.
- Be polite, give your ideas and views only, and do not argue with others.
- In case the entire group is shouting, as happens in some repeater groups, do not try to out shout others, but await your turn patiently. In case of total chaos it is sensible to state: "Gentlemen/ladies, let us not shout; let us make a consensus story!"
- Do not try to dominate the discussion by speaking more. The quality of your views is more important than how much you speak.
- Once the discussion stage starts treat the story that you narrated as just one of the 15 stories. Do not remain attached to it.
- If the story of the majority of the group is similar to yours, it is easy to contribute to the discussion.
- In case your story is different from the entire group, please speak with a view to reach at a consensus story.

Whatever you do, don't do this...

Don't outshout others! When you come to the discussion stage 75% of the assessment is already over and only your group behaviour is being assessed. Your ability to get along with the group as well as ability to influence the group is being assessed. By shouting you only display poor group behaviour. It is common practice for SSB repeaters to try and outshout each other in group discussion stage of PPDT. This is not a sensible practice. By doing so a candidate not only lowers his chances of success but that of others as well. I have explained as to why candidates should not *outshout in PPDT*.

Outlook of Outshouting

The practice of outshouting in PPDT displays a 'scarcity mentality'. Possession/display of this *outlook* lowers chances of selection. In simple words it displays the following qualities about the individual who is trying to outshout others:

- Lack of self confidence.
- Sense of insecurity.
- Poor team spirit.

Majority of the candidates who outshout display the outlook:

"Let me be unsuccessful but I will also make others fail with me!"

'Scarcity Mentality' versus 'Abundance Mentality'

Indian society is overly competitive. It has resulted in creation of a 'scarcity mentality' in the society. This attitude or paradigm is responsible for the failure of a large number of candidates in SSB. Let us analyse as to why candidates having a 'scarcity mentality' fail SSB? Before we analyse the reasons it is essential to be clear as to what is 'scarcity mentality' and 'abundance mentality'.

'Scarcity mentality', as opposed to 'abundance mentality' is the paradigm of an individual who feels that in general there is a scarcity. For such a person there is a scarcity of persons who will clear SSB, scarcity of food, scarcity of opportunities in life and anything that he/she considers important. This is the predominant psychological mindset of the individual. The paradigm is unsuited for teamwork and organisational success. Examples of behaviour displaying 'scarcity mentality':

- Since the individual is insecure about his getting screened in at SSB he will out shout others in PPDT discussion.
- As a child he will not share his toys, but try to snatch other's toys.
- He will try to take the maximum of the dish he likes.
- If in GD he had a point and someone else gives it before him, then he will get demoralised and feel cheated.

In contrast an individual having 'abundance mentality' paradigm is confident, relaxed and secure. He will not behave in the manner as given in the above examples.

'Abundance mentality' is the required paradigm for candidates getting selected. These candidates are relaxed, confident and secure. They do not want to beat others to get selected. They want to get selected and also help others to get selected. Such people are good team workers and assets to any organisation.

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Chapter 5:

TAT Sample Stories

I have written some blogs about psychology tests and specifically about Thematic Apperception Test (TAT) as well. Aspirants have been asking me to post some sample stories. I had not done that so far because the tendency to copy these stories by aspirants is high and also of trying to 'fit' these stories in somewhat similar photographs. Please do not do so! I have written some sample stories in this chapter.

Description: A house on fire and a man walking by

Story: Vivek was heading to his college when he heard screams of a lady from a house on fire. He rushed to the house and found that because of the strong wind it was difficult to douse the fire. He escorted the sole old lady occupant out of the house safely and informed the fire brigade. He took the help of some people who had gathered and neighbours to get buckets full of water and a water pipe to douse the fire. Some people brought some sticks and sand to beat the fire. On advice from the lady he retrieved the valuables from the house. By the time the fire brigade arrived the fire had already been controlled and could be quickly put off.

Description: A lady and a man working in laboratory

Story: Pia was pursuing her PhD on curing diseases in young children. As she researched the subject she realised that the children who had been kept in very hygienic environment were more susceptible to serious ailments because they had low immunity compared to the children who had been exposed to dirt and filth since birth. Her research work was greatly appreciated and it made the society aware that bringing up children in overly hygienic environment can be dangerous for their later lives because of lowered immunity.

Description: A lady standing at a crowded counter

Story: Rakhi went to an employment exchange centre and noticed that many people were crowding up the counter for various works. She met the exchange center head to allow her to develop an app which allowed people to register online for vacancies. She developed the app and added multiple facilities to manage data, send message alerts to the registered people and facilitated companies to book slots to meet the people. This helped improve the efficiency of the employment exchange.

Description: A man lying on bed and a woman crying at the door

Story: Maya's husband was ill. He had been diagnosed with dengue. She became sad and consulted the doctor. The doctor prescribed some medi-

cines, healthy diet and nutritional supplements. Maya took care of her husband and gave him medicines and healthy food as prescribed. After one and a half months her husband began to recover and in a span of 3 months became well. He was really happy after getting well and Maya was glad that her effort brought a positive impact on her husband.

Description: 5-6 soldiers lying huddled together

Story: Lt Ranjeet had had a tiring day with his soldiers in a successful counter insurgency operation. They had not slept for 2 days. So after finishing the operation they reported the successful completion of the operation to their senior and decided to relax. After relaxing for some time they returned to their location. They were felicitated for their bravery. The soldiers were really happy and were ready for future operations.

Description: A man and woman appearing agitated and one young lady shown separately in background

Story: Vijay was very fond of his younger sister, Rama, who was a very bright girl and had been a topper in the village school. In the rural culture of Haryana, girl education was not encouraged. Vijay's mother wanted her daughter to stop studying and learn household duties well and get married at an early age. Vijay wanted her sister to study and pursue her dream of becoming a doctor. After a heated discussion, Vijay convinced his mother to allow Rama to pursue higher studies. Rama became the first doctor from her village.

Description: Faces of an elder and a younger man wearing jackets and ties

Story: Mohan worked at a factory where Mr Verma was his boss. He had been working there for 9 years. He had joined the factory as a trainee and due to his hard work, sincerity and commitment he had become the Manager. Mr. Verma trusted and supported him. They decided to start manufacturing biodegradable packing bags for big items. Their product was good and found many buyers and got support from the government as well.

Description: A man at a graveyard

Story: Joseph had gone to the graveyard to pay homage to his departed grandfather. He had always been a source of inspiration and inculcated in him good ethical values and taught him to be modest and down to earth. He cleaned the grave, put flowers and remembered the good times they had had. He resolved to continue working in accordance with the good values inculcated in him by the departed soul. Joseph became an Air Force pilot.

Description: Accident of cart and car in middle of the road and a youth passing by

Story: Rajat was going to the market when he saw an accident of a car and a cart on the road. He immediately ran to the spot of accident and saw that the driver of the cart was badly injured and the driver of the car was unhurt. He called the police using his mobile. The car was functional. The police reached

the spot in 10 min. He took the cart driver in the car to the nearest hospital and informed his relatives. Once the relatives arrived and took over the patient he went home.

Description: A lady in European dress with a book standing in the foreground, while farming activity is on in the background

Story: Mary was the daughter of a farmer. She was a bright girl and wanted to raise the economic status of her family. She studied agricultural science and returned to her village. She took a small plot of her farm and used modern seeds and methods of cultivation to demonstrate the efficacy of her knowledge. The excellent results converted her parents into believing in her methods which were used on their entire farm next year. Their farm income trebled and they were very happy. Soon the entire village adopted the modern methods of farming and prospered.

Blank Slide Story

Sita was a young civil engineer who was hired to look into the failure of a fly-over bridge. She reviewed all the files, drawings, data-sheets of material purchased, quality reports of material used in the construction and the load calculations. She came to a conclusion that there was sub-standard construction material used. She decided to bring this out. She had to put up a brave fight against corrupt officers at every level. Sheer determination, courage and will to bring about justice to the affected families motivated her to keep fighting. In the end she won the case and was able to claim handsome compensation for the affected families.

Points to Note in the Stories

- No one has won PVC.
- No adjectives are used to describe the main character.
- No location of towns and districts is given.
- There are no unnecessary preambles given about the situation or the characters.
- The stories can be written easily within 3-4 minutes.
- The stories are relate to the pictures shown as also routine life events.
- When the scene is of a European location, and graveyard the characters are given suitable names.

Chapter 6:

Sample Solutions in SRT

Posing "challenge SRT" is a very fond practice among SSB aspirants. This is not a helpful exercise. I had been resisting requests for posting samples of psychology tests for long. Since aspirants keep seeking ideal answers I have written sample solutions to situations in SRT. Please note the following points/ clarifications:

1. It is sensible to give comprehensive solutions.
2. It is not sensible to give long solutions.
3. Effort should be made to solve maximum number of situations.
4. Proactive outlook and action is better than reactive.
5. Reactions displaying confidence and practical sense should be preferred over meek responses.
6. The solutions are given below adhere to the above guidelines. Take them as guidelines and not ideal solutions.

Sample Solutions

1) His captain was injured before a crucial match, he was asked to lead the team? He **led the team to victory.**

2) He was on his way to home and suddenly it started raining heavily? He **ran fast and reached home.**

3) You are an officer posted at the border and suddenly shelling happens from the other side, **you will order troops to stay in shell-proof bunkers, inform the CO and request for counter shelling.**

4) You are in an unknown city and lost your purse. You need money. As a stranger how will u manage? **I will ask my parents to send money through PayTm.**

5) Your brother wants to get admission in a medical college but his marks fall short by 1% for admission. **You'll ask him to try in other colleges where his marks are within cut-off.**

6) You have to go to a city with cash to work but the way is dangerous as dacoits. How will u manage to go? **I will avoid carrying cash and use the credit card.**

7) He was traveling by train and suddenly a person snatches purse from lady and jumps out of train. **He pulls chain, jumps down and catches the criminal, recover purse and handover criminal to police.**

8) You are going to sign a contract suddenly u got news that one of your friend who had helped you once met an accident and is in ICU. **You'll sign the contract and then go to the hospital to meet a friend.**

9) He had boarded a wrong train and came to know only when he was asked to pay money to TT. **He explained the situation to TT, apologised and took the right train.**

10) He saw his girlfriend walking with another person on his way. **He trusted his friend and did nothing.**

11) He was on his way to the railway station to catch a train; suddenly a car passes by and throws a person out of the running car. **He will help the person with the appropriate first aid, inform police, and then catch his train.**

12) He was driving the bike without a helmet and the traffic police caught him. **He apologised, paid fine and never repeated the mistake.**

13) He was asked to organise the farewell party. **He organised it well.**

14) He was ironing his clothes when suddenly he received an electric shock and he noticed the wire burning. **He will turn the switch off, remove the plug and get the iron repaired.**

15) He was in charge of the wireless board in a sailing ship which lost its communication with the coast. **He restored communication quickly.**

16) In a discussion with your colleagues, you find your losing ground, **you will agree to their better logic.**

17) He was to appear for an exam and all of a sudden the curfew was imposed in that area, **he showed admit card to the police and took the exam.**

18) He went for the picnic with his friends and on the way he had hot arguments with them. **He will calm down the situation and enjoy the picnic.**

19) There is a person who sells smuggled goods. You too, like many others, have purchased a wristwatch from him. But it doesn't work. **You'll ask for the replacement.**

20) Just two days before the semi-finals of the bridge tournament, his partner was called by his parents and had to go out of station for an urgent work. **He took another partner and won.**

21) He was rather young when his father was killed in the war and later mother kidnapped by the rival group. He had no other relative. **He approached the Police to get his mother back and register case against the criminals.**

22) You are on the way to your home suddenly your bicycle got punctured. **You'll get down, walk with the cycle, get it repaired and ride back home.**

23) He urgently needed of money. **He took it from parents.**

24) During d exams his teacher threatened him to fail in examination. **He prepared and performed well and ignored the empty threat.**

25) You are getting late in reaching meeting. **You would inform the organiser and reach at the earliest.**

SRT Samples Considered Difficult

There are quite a few SRT samples which are considered as difficult or 'tricky' by aspirants. One of my students has compiled them and I have written the responses as a guide.

Sample Responses

1. He receives conflicting orders from his two superior officers. **He went to his immediate reporting officer and told him the conflicting order received from the other senior and after clarification obeyed the order.**
2. He was going to attend SSB interview. On reaching the Railway Station he noticed that his suitcase has been stolen with his original certificates needed at SSB. **He immediately lodged an FIR, went back and got the original certificates from the college and then attended SSB.**

3. While he was traveling on his scooter, someone at gunpoint demanded his purse. **He rammed the scooter into him, took his gun and lodged FIR against the criminal.**
4. He was going on a bicycle in thick jungle. It was already dark and his destination was 10 Km away. His cycle got punctured. **He walked with the cycle to destination.**
5. He is new in the city. Suddenly he noticed that all his items were stolen. He had no money in his pocket. **He got money from home through PAYTM, lodged FIR and managed.**
6. He observed a Cobra was approaching his brother who was sleeping in a room at night. **He struck the Cobra on the head and killed it with one stroke.**
7. He was in a NCC Camp. While on guard duty at mid night , he observed a person crossing the fence and getting in. **He challenged him and the person ran away.**
8. While negotiating a forest with his friend, his friend lost consciousness due to exhaustion. **He gave him water, made him recover, rested a little and continued walking.**
9. He was caught alone at night by thugs who demanded all valuables on him while he was unarmed. **He, being an athlete, ran away and could not be caught.**
10. While crossing a jungle, he observed that a tiger was standing just 10 yards from him. **He quietly and quickly climbed a tree.**

11. While going through a jungle, he noticed that someone was following him with a rifle. **He joined him and they walked together.**
12. He was on leave in his village. Once at night he got up due to firing sound and cries of the villagers. He noticed that village was attacked by dacoits. **He immediately informed the Police, organised the villagers and young men with firearms fought the dacoits till the arrival of Police.**
13. He and his friend were arguing over a topic later he found that his friend was correct. **He thanked his friend for educating him.**
14. While going through a forest with his brother, he lost the way and it had become dark. **He managed his way through the GPS.**
15. While coming back from late night movie show he saw 5 men are harassing a girl. **He shouted and scared the criminals away and later dropped the girl home.**
16. His mother is seriously ill and his boss doesn't grant him leave. **He promises his boss that he will complete the assigned work, take leave and attend to his mother.**
17. While traveling in the train, his compartment got fire. **He pulled the chain to stop the train and helped the passengers evacuate the compartment and railway staff to fight the fire.**

18. He was forced to vote the candidate whom he doesn't like. **He voted for the candidate of his choice.**

19. While watching movie in a movie theatre, he saw a snake near his legs. **He stomped on its head and killed it.**

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Chapter 7:

Sample Sentences for **Word Association Test (WAT)**

I have been asked by a large number of students to write sample sentences for WAT. I was not doing so because I was worried that it may encourage students to memorise and write these sentences. I have now given these samples because aspirants are in any case learning a lot of wrong things. Just note that these are simple and grammatically correct sentences. Please ignore all other advice about WAT.

Sample Sentences

1. Help – Helping others spreads goodwill.
2. Organise- An organised room is an indication of an organised mind.
3. Action- In an emergency it is better to act quickly rather than keep pondering.
4. Determination- A determined man can achieve anything.
5. Imagination- Imagination has no limits.

6. Friends- Friends are the family we choose.
7. Lively- Lively people are good company.
8. Courage- Courageous men inspire generations.
9. Mind- The mind is the most powerful human organ.
10. Neighbour- Neighbours are good to you when you are good to them.
11. Group- Group cohesion leads to success.
12. Strength- Strength can be built with systematic effort.
13. Reasonable- Reasonable prices attract customers.
14. Sister- Sister is another form of mother.
15. Speed- Speed often beats strength.
16. Timid- Timid people cannot be great leaders.
17. Knowledge- Knowledge is more powerful than money.
18. Country- A strong country is made by honest citizens.
19. Dependence- Dependence is often seen in old age.
20. Brave- Brave men inspire men and children alike.

21.Expression- Simple and clear expression is well understood.

22.Emotions- Emotions are unique to everyone.

23.Action- Action drives results.

24.Health- Healthy lifestyle comes with discipline.

25.Awareness- General awareness is improved by reading.

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Chapter 8:

Self -Description Test

In the psychology test of SSB you are required to write your self-description, which includes the opinions of parents, teachers, friends as well as your own. Often in interview questions as given below get asked:

- How would your best friend describe you?
- How would your boss describe you?

SSB aspirants should go prepared with what to write in their self-description so that it can be written well and quickly in the test and questions can be answered well without trying to think too hard during the SSB. Self-description will be unique to every individual. However, a sample self-description of a candidate is given below to guide SSB aspirants on the subject.

Parents' Opinion

My parents know that I am honest, responsible and independent. They appreciate my concern for them and my younger brother's well-being. They appreciate my being confident and competent in academics as well as extra-curricular activities. They are confident that I will have a good future and bring a good name to the family. At times, they feel that I tend to be a little over-confident and advise me to stay grounded.

Teachers' Opinion

My teachers considered me disciplined, punctual and respectful. They found me bright, responsible and an all-rounder. They believed that I could carry out any responsibility given to me with full enthusiasm. As such, I was appointed the Head- girl. They sometimes advised me to be less talkative. They feel that I will have a bright career.

Employer's Opinion

My manager and team take me as responsible, helpful, hardworking and dedicated. They appreciate my zeal to keep learning as also accepting my faults and improving upon them.

Friends' Opinion

My friends know that I am lively, helpful and totally trustworthy. They consult me about their various problems. They like my company. They feel I can adapt to any situation. They like me for my commitment. They appreciate my being focused on my career. They advise me not to trust people too easily.

Own Opinion

I am a responsible daughter, trustworthy friend and reliable worker. For me, my work is worship. I am helpful to my friends as well as colleagues. In difficult times, I prefer to stay calm and resolve the problems.

Aspects I would like to Improve

I think I did not done justice to my academic potential in my school and college. I have resolved to rectify this aspect now. I need to improve my physical fitness as well as general awareness and have been working on the issues with reasonable success.

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Bonus Content

The bonus chapters have been added to this book in response to the scores of requests from defence aspirants to shed some light on GTO tasks in general and GPE in particular. Another chapter on an overview to the entire SSB process, with a brief summation of the concepts and tips described in the chapters above, has also been added. It is hoped that the additions will prove helpful to the reader.

Chapter 9:

How to Get Ideas in GTO Tasks?

Get the Big Picture

Generating workable ideas in GTO tasks, namely, Progressive Group Task (PGT), Half Group Task (HGT), Command Task (CT) and Final Group Task (FGT) is a challenge. Let us understand the big picture in order to solve the tasks.

- **Practical Knowledge.** Your theoretical academic knowledge will not be of much use but practical knowledge will be required to solve the tasks.
- **Genuine Worth Gets Known.** At the end of the GTO tasks you will be able to assess the calibre of the candidates in your group as also the comparative rating of the group. Since you can do it then it is safe to assume that the GTO, who is an expert assessor, will definitely be able to do so. Hence it is sensible to work calmly in a cooperative spirit.
- **Focus on Task.** Indian society is over-competitive and in general the aim of the candidates is to give impressive ideas to get into the lime light. This attitude is not conducive to team synergy. The usual worries troubling an insecure candidate's mind are:
 1. Some others will not allow him to give ideas.
 2. If he has an idea then someone will state it earlier than him.

3. Others will adopt his ideas as their own and he will be deprived of due credit.

Thus most candidates are able to focus with not more than 70% of their brain on doing the task. A confident candidate should focus his 100% energy on solving the task in the spirit of being a good team-man.

- **Effective Team-man.** An effective team-man is much better than an intelligent but dysfunctional group member. Hence please behave in the right spirit.

Developing Ability to Solve Practical Problems

We develop our abilities to solve practical problems in life by facing them. A student gets opportunities to develop these abilities through sports, extra-curricular activities and organising things at home/school/college. A working professional gets ample opportunities to improve his problem solving skills through doing his work with dedication. The GTO is trying to assess these qualities because it is highly unlikely that after becoming an officer a person would have to solve PGT in his professional career. A person who sits at home and prepares for competitive exams only is likely to be less competent in this facet of personality than a person who is working in the field. Hence, develop yourself by leading an all round productive life. This is the most effective method.

Developing Ability to Solve Specific GTO Tasks

It is important to have an idea about solving the tasks like PGT. You have 3 items to help you cross the obstacles, namely plank, log & a rope. Here are some important points to remember:

- In 90% of the situations the plank would be used to bridge the gap required to be crossed.
- Securing firmly one end of the plank would be the key to cross obstacles.
- The plank may get secured by the following means:
 1. Resting atop a suitable place to walk across.
 2. Putting it in some wedge.
 3. By tying it on a suitable platform using the rope.
 4. Tying the rope across two posts may create a platform on which one end of the plank gets secured.
 5. There may be various other means to do so as well.
- The log may get used to cross shorter gaps or extend the length of the plank with the help of the rope.
- It would be helpful to watch some of the numerous videos about GTO tasks available on Youtube to get acquainted with the obstacles and methods of crossing them.

Chapter 10:

Group Planning Exercise

Group planning exercise is an important exercise in the **GTO** series. It is the only task in which a written plan is submitted & studied by the GTO in detail. I have discussed the common mistakes which candidates make & what they should do to ensure good performance.

Common Mistakes

- Ignoring the time plan. This is the most common mistake. Accomplishing the tasks in the required time is important. Time is a limited resource and hence judicious utilisation is essential to an effective plan. It must be given due respect. In the time plan at times candidates tend to make impractical assumptions which should not be done:
 - Example: If a person has to be admitted in a hospital then the travel time as well as time taken to get him admitted must be considered realistically. Just taking the return journey time is impractical.
- Wasting Time in Stupid Tasks. I remember some stupid tasks which cannot be done being attempted by candidates. Examples (You are a group of students on picnic):

- A monkey owner requests you to locate his monkey who has run away.
- A lady requests you to recover her buffalo from marshy land.
- A man asks you to save his dry haystack which has caught fire.
- 'Rambo' Tasks Attempted by Impractical Candidates: A large number of candidates behave like 'Rambo' (Stallone movie character) & do tasks like:
 - Catching terrorists.
 - Killing dacoits with 12 bore guns taken from villagers.

Avoiding Common Mistakes

To avoid common mistakes please make a realistic time plan & not undertake stupid and 'Rambo' tasks. Let the 'Rambo' tasks be done by the police. You should just inform the police.

Interesting Practical Problem

During the discussion stage in a group full of coached candidates not much consensus is arrived at. A stupid individual who is convinced that he must dominate the *group* appoints himself to be the consensus leader to narrate the plan on behalf of the *group*. He is by no means the nominated leader. The plan he narrates is his plan and not a consensus plan of the *group*. This plan has obviously some serious shortcomings. The *group* does not object to

the disagreeable points of the plan narrated thinking that it will be wrong to disagree with the plan of the leader. In some cases there are a few candidates who are much more sensible and could have given a much better and acceptable plan. The *GTO* at times asks them whether they agree with the plan narrated. These candidates confirm to the *GTO* that they agree with the plan, once again thinking that this is the right thing to do.

What should You Do?

The group in this situation is a disorganised group. The leader has not been nominated by consensus. This is known to all the candidates in the group and definitely by the *GTO*. In this situation you must speak and ask the parts of the plan which are unacceptable to be changed. In case the *GTO* asks you, then you must convey your differences to the plan told. Why this is the right thing to do?

- Your aim as a part of the group is to make the best possible plan for the group to be effective in performing the task most efficiently.
- By stating the changes to the plan you have achieved that objective.
- By expressing disagreement with the leader you have done no wrong because he is not the nominated leader and nor is the plan a consensus plan. It is not against the wrongly perceived military ethos!
- By not expressing disagreement you have made yourself party to a poor plan. The *GTO* has all reasons to consider your planning abilities to be as poor as the plan presented.

Group planning exercise is an important part of the GTO series. To perform well in this task please ensure that you do the following:

- Make a realistic time plan & submit a brief but comprehensive plan.
- Do not plan to accomplish the stupid and 'Rambo' tasks.
- Do not agree with the stupid plan of a self-appointed leader.
- Do not get into an altercation but guide the group towards a sensible, practical & simple plan.

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SSB SCHEDULE

DAY 1 (REPORTING DAY)

As per the call letter, usually, the reporting time is in the afternoon & place is Movement Control Office (MCO), located at the Railway Station. You will not find it difficult as there will be many other candidates who will be scheduled to report on the same day, & you are likely to find some of them.

For some entries reporting day and Screening day are same, so please follow your call letters for correct information. In such case, reporting time is likely to be early morning, like 0700 hours.

On reporting day you are given a detailed brief about the tests & instructions & timings for various things. PIQ (Personal Information Questionnaire) forms are to be filled (similar to the one which I get filled).

DAY 2 (STAGE 1 TESTING/SCREENING)

Screening is the process designed to select potential candidates, from all those who have reported for the particular entry, for Stage 2 of testing, or complete SSB process. It comprises the following:

Officer's Intelligence Rating (OIR) Test

It is similar to the intelligence tests of reasoning (verbal & non-verbal) given in various competitive examinations preparatory books & magazines. Rea-

soning ability, as well as the speed of reasoning, is important. It is advisable to practice these to get a good score.

Screening Test

Picture Perception & Description Test (PPDT)

It involves two aspects- first is writing a story, & second is a discussion on the story. You will be shown a black & white, hazy picture for 30 secs. You are required to write some particulars in the available box in the answer sheet, which includes No of Characters, their Age, Sex & Mood. You have to identify the main character & build the story around him/her. It is convenient to name the character (helps in discussion stage). You are required to describe what the scene in the picture depicts (what is going on). You have to visualize & write, what led to the present scene (what happened in the past). You have to foresee the future & write it. (What will happen in the future). The entire story has to be written in about 3 mins & submitted.

Tips for Story Writing

Avoid

Pre-prepared Story: Some coached candidates (generally ACC & SCO entries), come with a misconception that the time is too less to make a story & hence come with a pre-prepared story & fit it there. Often the main character in such stories is narrated as a young man who joins the Defence Services & also gets a decoration! There is nothing in the picture to suggest any of these things. There are several such "positive" coaching academy type stories which can be easily found out by the assessors. Such stories have an adverse

impact on the clearance of Stage 1 by the subject candidate. Stories Displaying Wrong Interpretation of Positive Thinking. Experience shows that quite a few coached candidates are over-enthusiastic about "positive thinking" & display it in an unnatural manner in their stories. E.g: In an obviously tragic scene such candidates will state that the mood of the main character is positive. Such stories can be easily found out & have an adverse impact on the clearance of Stage 1 by the subject candidate.

Abide

Write a natural & realistic story that comes to your mind on seeing the picture. The moods, etc of characters should be stated as observed.

POSITIVE THINKING MEANS THAT EVEN IF THE PICTURE SHOWS SOMETHING ADVERSE, OR TRAGIC, THE CANDIDATE FORESEES THAT IN THE FUTURE THINGS WILL BECOME ALL RIGHT, WITH THE MAIN CHARACTER PLAYING A PROACTIVE PART IN THE SAME.

THE MAIN CHARACTER SHOULD BE PROACTIVE & DO SOMETHING FOR THE BETTERMENT OF THE EXISTING SITUATION.

Discussion Requirement

Candidates are organised in groups of 14-15 for group discussion. Each candidate is required to narrate his story in turn. After everyone has narrated his/her story the group is required to discuss the same & arrive at a consensus story. The group is required to nominate a leader who has to narrate the story on behalf of the entire group.

Tips for Discussion:

- Narrate your story confidently in a clear voice in about one minute.

- Remain confident about being selected, remain relaxed & do not feel pressurised to force your views on others, in the fear that others will dominate you.
- Never look at the assessors while narrating the story, or during the discussion.
- Listen to the speakers attentively.
- Be polite, give your ideas & views only, & do not argue with others.
- **IN CASE THE ENTIRE GROUP IS SHOUTING, AS HAPPENS IN SOME REPEATER GROUPS, DO NOT TRY TO OUT SHOUT OTHERS, BUT AWAIT YOUR TURN PATIENTLY.**
- Do not try to dominate the discussion by speaking more. The quality of your views is more important than how much you speak.
- Do not repeat your views.
- Help the weak members to talk.
- If the story of the majority of the group is similar to yours, it is easy to contribute to the discussion.
- In case your story is different from the entire group, it is sensible to change your views & help the group in forming a consensus story, rather than trying to guide the group towards your perspective.

Results of Screening: After the completion of PPDT, you will get a break of 2-3 hours. Screening results will be declared after it. Selected candidates are allotted with new chest numbers. Rest of the candidates gets their TA and dropped backed to the railway station.

DAY 3 (STAGE 2 TESTING)

PLEASE DO NOT WASTE TIME TO PRACTICE ALL THESE TESTS. WORK TO GENUINELY IMPROVE YOUR PERSONALITY. LEAVE THE ASSESSMENT TO THE EXPERTS!

Following Psychology tests are conducted:

Thematic Apperception Test [TAT]

Word Association Test [WAT]

Situation Reaction Test [SRT]

Self Description Test [SD]

TAT

You will be shown 11 black & white pictures in which the last picture is a blank slide. Each picture will come just for 30 seconds and then disappear, after that you will get 4 minutes to write the story based on that picture. After 4 mins another picture will come for 30 seconds and same process will be followed till last slide {blank slide}. The tips for TAT are the same as for the story of PPDT. Go prepared with the story for the blank slide.

WAT

You will be shown 60 words back to back; each word will remain on the screen for 15secs. In 15secs you are required to write a sentence which comes to your mind first after reading that word. Likewise, you have to write 60 sentences continuously without any pause in between.

Tips:

It is not possible to go prepared with 60 sentences, as some coached candidates try to do & in fact succeed in writing quite a few such sentences. This does not help, because only the spontaneous response is consistent with the personality of the candidate. The psychologist analyses the complete responses to construct a holistic & consistent personality of the individual. Any prepared response will be inconsistent with the complete battery of answers & hence will get ignored.

SRT

You will get a booklet with 60 situations written on it. You are required to write your responses based on those 60 situations. Time allotted will be 30 mins.

Tips: Answer spontaneously. The main character in the situations should be a leader, who should try to resolve the problems proactively for the betterment of everyone & not wait for things to happen.

SD

You are required to write opinion about you from your parents, friends, teachers & yourself, and things which you would like to develop in the future. Time allotted will be 15 mins.

Tips: You should go prepared. Write the truth. Opinions of others, as well as yourself about you are basically a brief about your strong & weak points. The strong points should be more than the weak points. In case the reverse is true, it shows that you have not taken enough action to improve yourself, despite being aware of your weaknesses.

OVERALL TIPS FOR PSYCHOLOGY TESTS WOULD BE TO THINK FAST; WRITE FAST, LEGIBLY & INCORRECT SEQUENCE.

IT IS NOT MANDATORY TO COMPLETE EVERYTHING, BUT THE CANDIDATE WHO CAN COMPLETE EVERYTHING DEFINITELY THINKS FASTER & HAS BETTER MENTAL STAMINA THAN THE ONE WHO DOES NOT.

DAYS 4 & 5: GTO TESTS

GTO tests are a series of outdoor tests, designed to judge your qualities during group performance. Remember most of the tasks in this series are group tasks. You are required to support the group with the best of your abilities and not to compete with them in any manner.

Series of Tests

GD

Discussion is on two topics, one is a debatable topic from current affairs & the other is on a social issue.

Tips: Are same as for PPDT discussion.

GPE

It is an important test in the GTO series. A situation is given to you. It is supported by a map. Invariably a group of persons has to go from one place to another, in a limited time & accomplish an important task. In between problems are confronted which need to be resolved, & in case a problem is unimportant & resolution will prevent you from accomplishing the main task then it has to be ignored, or resolved to the extent that the main task is not jeopardised. A written, individual, solution has to be submitted. The group has to discuss the plan, arrive at a consensus plan, and nominate a leader to narrate the plan. It is a comprehensive test, which brings out the aspects of logical thinking, ability to convince others with your views, accept ideas from others which are better than yours, or are more acceptable to others.

Tips: Concentrate to understand the situation well. Submit a comprehensive & well written plan. Be prepared to accept others' ideas. Do not try to resolve any intermediary problem which will prevent you from accomplishing the main task.

PGT

In Progressive Group Task, the group is required to cross some obstacles with the help of supporting materials like rope, plank, wooden log etc. Some rules are required to be followed during this task. It is a full group activity.

HGT

Half Group Task is similar to PGT but the number of group members will be half, so you may get more chance to show your potential.

IOT

In Individual Obstacles Task, you are required to attempt 10 obstacles individually; each obstacle consists of some points from 1 to 10.

Tips: It appears to be mainly a test of speed & strength, but is not so. Plan the sequence of crossing the obstacles with a view to score maximum marks earliest. If you are in doubt about clearing an obstacle attempt it towards the end. In case you have begun to cross an obstacle, then do not leave it in between, as this displays lack of determination & self confidence.

Command Task

You will be a commander in this task, & are required to cross some obstacles with the help of 2-3 subordinates. You can choose 2-3 candidates from your own group whom you think can help you to clear the obstacles.

Tips: Choose subordinates based on competence, rather than friendship. In case you are stuck, ask ideas from subordinates. CT is assigned to each candidate based on his abilities. In case your CT is quite difficult, then be happy, your IQ has been well rated.

Snake Race/Group Obstacle Course

All group members will be competing with other groups. Members will be holding a snake like rope; they are required to cross certain obstacles with

the snake. There are certain rules like all other tasks. It is a kind of race among different groups.

Tips: Use your abilities to help the group finish the race fastest.

Individual Lecture

Each candidate has to speak for 3 mins on a topic selected by him/her out of 3-4 topics.

FGT

FGT is similar to PGT.

Tips for PGT, HGT, CT & FGT: Initially it will be difficult to understand the use of the helping material in crossing obstacles. Do not worry, keep thinking & observing. Ideas utilized in crossing one obstacle will have relevance in others as well. After PGT you will have better ideas for later tasks. Each task has more than one solution. Please adhere to instructions.

DAY 4 OR 5 (PERSONAL INTERVIEW)

The Interviewing officer has your Personal Information Questionnaire (PIQ) form, which provides him the base for your interview. He starts talking in a relaxed manner to make you feel comfortable. He then asks you a series of questions to which you are expected to answer in the same sequence. He keeps asking small questions in between. He again asks you a series of questions, to be replied as earlier.

Tips: Be relaxed & confident of being selected. Write only truth in the PIQ form, without exaggeration. Listen carefully to the questions, without getting excited. Answer the questions in the sequence asked. Have good knowledge about your favourite subjects, sports, hobbies, etc. If you say that you have read a book, or seen a movie, or TV program, then you should know about it well. Be prepared to explain organisation of an event from your hobbies, sports or extra-curricular activities, you have been involved in.

DAY 6 (SSB CONFERENCE)

In the conference, each candidate faces all the SSB assessors together. The decision about selection of candidates is taken in the conference by the assessors. Each case is discussed in detail to take a deliberate decision. **AS REGARDS YOU, IT IS JUST A FORMALITY, AS DECISIONS ARE TAKEN BASED ON TESTS CONDUCTED EARLIER & NOT CONFERENCE.** Usually, questions about food, experience & stay are asked by the Interviewing Officer. Only short answers are warranted.



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